It helps to maintain ecological processes, create soil, recycle nutrients, influence climate, degrade waste and control diseases. It provides an index of health of an ecosystem.The survival of human race depends on the existence and wellbeing of all life forms (plants and animals) in the biosphere.

12.1.1 Concept of biodiversity

The term biodiversity was introduced by Walter Rosen (1986). Biodiversity is the assemblage of different life forms. Each species is adapted to live in its specific environments.

The changes in climatic conditions are reflected in the distribution and pattern of biodiversity on our planet. The number of species per unit area declines as we move from tropics towards the poles. The Tundra and Taiga of northern Canada, Alaska, northern Europe and Russia possess less than 12 species of trees. The temperate forests of the United states have 20-35 species of trees, while the tropical forests of Panama have over 110 species of trees in a relatively small area.

12.1.2 Levels of biodiversity

Edward Wilson popularized the term 'Biodiversity' to describe diversity at all levels of biological organization from populations to biomes. There are three levels of biodiversity – Genetic diversity, Species diversity and Community/Ecosystem diversity (**Fig. 12.1**).

Genetic diversity refers to the differences in genetic make-up (number and types of genes) between distinct species and to the genetic variation within a single species; also covers genetic variation between distinct populations of the same species. Genetic diversity can be measured using a variety of molecular techniques. India has more than 50,000 genetic variants of Paddy and 1000 variants of Mango. Variation of genes of a species increases with diversity in size and habitat. It results in the formation of different races, varieties and subspecies. *Rouwolfia vomitaria*, a medicinal plant growing in different ranges of the Himalayas shows differences in the potency and concentration of the active ingredient reserpine due to genetic diversity. Genetic diversity helps in developing adaptations to changing environmental conditions.

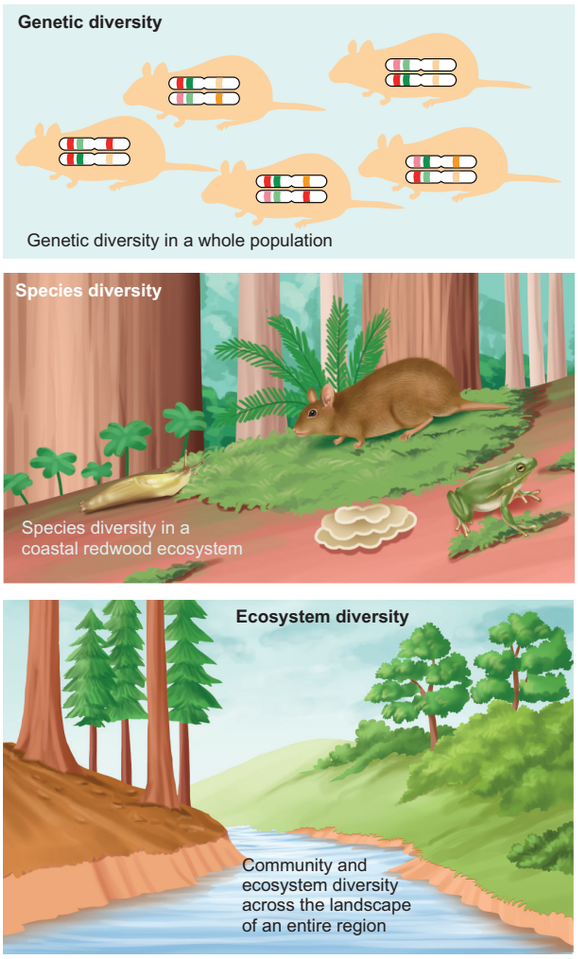


Fig. 12.1 Three levels of biodiversity

Species diversity refers to the variety in number and richness of the species in any habitat. The number of species per unit area at a specific time is called species richness, which denotes the measure of species diversity. The Western Ghats have greater amphibian species diversity than the Eastern Ghats. The more the number of species in an area the more is the species richness **(Fig. 12.1a)**. The three indices of diversity are - Alpha, Beta and Gamma diversity.

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